a decade had largely dropped from the public discourse—except for a single event in Hebron.

Elor Azaria, the soldier discussed at the beginning of this book, was eventually found guilty. The presiding judge, Maya Heller, spent nearly three hours reading the entirety of her lengthy verdict. She made it clear that Azaria did not act in the heat of battle; rather, he had intended to kill a Palestinian. Military prosecutors had only charged Azaria with manslaughter. Her verdict suggested that they could have tried for murder. He would later be sentenced to eighteen months in prison—a remarkably light term for an offense that carries up to twenty years. The military officers I spoke with were largely satisfied, though: Azaria was merely a grunt, they argued.

But they were less sanguine about how the trial had turned him into a right-wing icon: his face appeared on T-shirts; politicians rushed to defend him and demand a presidential pardon. Outside the heavily-guarded courtroom, hundreds of his supporters blocked roads and scuffled with police, and at least one Israeli journalist was roughed up. “Azaria got what he deserved”, one officer said. “But how many other Azarias are out there?”

The generals

The men lined up along the red carpet, nearly two dozen career officers, had centuries of military experience between them. They were waiting for the guest of honor, and their new boss, who had about eighteen months of it.

The generals were silent. Most of them smiled when Avigdor Lieberman arrived in a black SUV. Still, it was hard not to imagine their inner monologues. The career officers of the Israeli army, after all, are used to serving under like-minded leaders: three of the four previous defense ministers served as army chiefs and retired with the rank of lieutenant general before they ascended to the top of the Kirya, the defense ministry in Tel Aviv. Lieberman, who was twenty years old when he made *aliyah*, did a shortened program of military service for new immigrants past the age of conscription. He moved quickly into politics, and for the next two decades he showed little interest in the nuances of Israel’s security policy. Eretz Nehederet (“A Wonderful Country”), a popular satirical program, imagined his first meeting with a military aide. “From today, no more aerial photos,”